

The Everglades

North America's only subtropical wetland system, dominated by iconic sawgrass prairies, and known locally as the "river of grass"



Located at the southern tip of the Florida peninsula, the Everglades is a vast wetland wilderness containing a variety of lowland habitats. Much of the inland area is covered by the famous sawgrass prairies that are permanently inundated with water. This so-called river of grass, which also contains lakes, waterways (sloughs), and cypress marshes at its edges, is dependent on fires—usually started by lightning strikes—for maintenance and regeneration. Islands of hardwood forests, known as hammocks, contain a mixture of trees including tropical mahogany and temperate oaks and maples, while some of the highest areas, including dry ridges, are covered in South Florida slash pine. In coastal areas, where freshwater and saltwater merge, salt marshes and tidal mangroves dominate. The combined mangrove system of the Everglades lining the coast, creeks, and estuaries is the largest in the Western Hemisphere.

Critical habitats

A major migration stopover, the Everglades is home to more than 400 species of birds. Some 50 species of reptiles live in the area, and it is the only place in the world where alligators and crocodiles coexist. The wetland provides critical habitats for many threatened and endangered species.

▷ LOCAL WADER

Roseate spoonbills roost in trees, then fly to their feeding grounds at sunrise, where they search for fish and other small prey.



△ UNDERWATER GRAZERS

A West Indian manatee mother and nursing calf graze in shallow waters on seagrasses and other aquatic plants.

◁ WINDING SLOUGHS

A series of slow-moving sloughs snake a route through sawgrass before emptying their freshwater into the brackish waters of an Everglades estuary.

▷ CYPRESS SWAMP

Found throughout the Everglades, cypress swamps are populated by trees that have adapted to flooded conditions. They are home to many species, including crocodilians.

One in three people living in Florida **rely** on the Everglades for their **water supply**

ECOLOGICAL SUCCESSION

This cross-section of the Everglades shows the relationship between different vegetation types and water inundation levels. The forested areas develop slowly as layers of organic material build up and elevate the land. The change from one type to the next, known as succession, may be affected by fire or environmental factors and may even be reversed.

